

DWAYNE & QIANA

Where are we waking up?

Thursday, October 1 → Sunday, October 4, 2026 · three nights

You said overwater bungalow. So I went and found every single one we can actually reach from Chicago in three nights, priced them out, and threw away the ones that don't work. Here they are. Pick one.

QIANA PICKED IT

Palafitos, Riviera Maya

"really wanted the over water bungalow" · "an inclusive with the bungalows and can use SW"

Working on two things now: whether we can put a deposit down and pay the rest over time instead of all at once, and the spa. Everything below stays here so you can keep looking.

YOU ASKED WHAT THERE IS TO DO

Two days in the Riviera Maya

Everything below was checked twice. Prices are per couple. The ones marked included cost nothing extra.

THE MOMENT

Set an alarm for 6:15 on Friday. **Sunrise is at 6:38** and the pier is completely empty before it. Open the doors onto our own deck, go down our own ladder, and get in the Caribbean while the light comes up. It is 84 degrees in the water. The fish we have been watching through the glass floor since we arrived are right there under us. That is the whole reason to pick this place over anywhere else on the page, and it costs nothing.

INCLUDED

The spa, which you asked about

Here is the part I did not know when I built this page. **There is an overwater spa at the end of our own pier.** Four treatment suites out over the water at the far end of the Palafitos section, and you can have the massage **with the windows open** so you hear the ocean underneath you the whole time. That is a couples massage over the Caribbean, forty steps from our own door.

The **All & More Inclusive rate already covers massages, facials and body scrubs**, and the hydrotherapy circuit is complimentary before any booked treatment: sauna, eucalyptus steam, a Scottish shower, hot and cold plunge pools, then juices. The paid upgrade is a signature ritual for two, roughly **\$400 to \$650**. Ask for the overwater suite specifically when we book, and put it in an afternoon so a rainy hour costs us nothing.

\$70 TO \$160

INCLUDED

The Overwater Grill, at the end of our own pier

Palafitos guests get a restaurant nobody else at the resort can use, sitting out over the water at the end of our pier, with private lounges that have **glass floors so you watch the sea underneath you while you eat**. Dinner runs 6 to 10. This is the best fit for a three night trip because it costs us zero travel time. I could not find a published price for a private beach dinner setup, so that is a question for the resort rather than a number I will make up.

\$150 TO \$220

Snorkeling the second largest reef on earth

The Mesoamerican Reef sits about 500 meters off Puerto Morelos, fifteen minutes up the road, so the boat ride is ten minutes instead of an hour. It is a protected national park with a daily cap on how many people go in, which is why it still looks like something. Two drifts of about forty minutes over elkhorn and brain coral. October visibility is usually good because the summer seaweed is receding. Small risk: a north wind can close the park for a day.

Sunset catamaran, five minutes down the beach

Marina Maroma is right next door, so we walk. Push off around 4:30, sail south with our own bungalow shrinking behind us, and be pointed west when the sun drops around 6:35. **This is the most weather sensitive thing on the list** and sunset sails do cancel for wind in early October, so book it for the first evening rather than the last and keep the other night free.

\$120 TO \$180

A morning in the cenotes

Thirty minutes inland the jungle road opens onto sinkholes of cold, glass clear fresh water, twenty of them along one stretch of highway. At Siete Bocas you go down a wooden stair into a cave and swim between seven openings with stalactites overhead.

Cenotes are groundwater fed, so seaweed and rain do not affect them. This is the rainy day insurance policy.

\$139 TO \$299

Tulum at the 8 a.m. gate

Grey limestone temples on a low cliff straight above turquoise water, the only walled Maya city built on the coast. About an hour and ten each way. **Go at opening or do not go.** There is almost no shade on the site and by ten it is hot, humid and packed. At eight you get an hour of cool air and empty paths. Figure six to eight hours door to door, so this eats a full day.

\$80 TO \$170

Dinner in Puerto Morelos

A working fishing town of about ten thousand that never got the Playa del Carmen treatment. One small square, a handicrafts market, a crooked lighthouse a 1967 hurricane knocked off plumb that the town decided to leave standing, and

PLANNING

Which days are actually free

Thursday is gone and Sunday is gone.

Thursday we fly four hours, clear immigration at Cancun and transfer forty minutes, and we will want that first evening on the deck doing nothing. Sunday we have to be at the airport three hours before an

seafood places where the catch came in that morning. Fifteen minutes north. October empties it out, which makes it better.

international flight. **That leaves Friday and Saturday.** My honest advice is to use one of them and stay on property for the other. Tulum Friday at the 8 a.m. gate, reef or sunset sail Saturday, spa in whichever afternoon it rains.

SKIP IT

Whale sharks and Xcaret

Whale shark season is closed. Mexico's legal window for 2026 ran June 15 to September 15 and operators stopped around the 17th. By October 1 there are no legal tours, so if anyone offers one it is not a licensed operation. And Xcaret is \$378 for the two of us for a theme park with wristbands, lines, buffets and a two hour show. It is impressive and it is the least romantic possible way to spend an anniversary day.

SKIP IT

Chichén Itzá

I looked into this properly because it is the thing everyone says you have to do. **The answer is no, not on this trip.** It is three hours each way. The bus tours run twelve to fourteen hours and most build in a jewelry shop stop you cannot skip. And the train does not rescue it: there is no morning departure, the only connection leaves at 7:10 p.m., so we would have to sleep in Valladolid. We have two days. Spending one of them in a van is not the trip.

OPTION SET 1

We fly

Four that fit three nights, and four that look great until you check the flight.

RIVIERA MAYA · MEXICO

MY PICK

Palafitos

Overwater Bungalows · adults only · All & More Inclusive

Fly from Midway, nonstop

In the air 3h 40m

Airport to room 45 to 60 min drive

Door to door about 7 hours

All inclusive Yes, All & More Inclusive

Spa treatments Massages included

Airport shuttle Included, both ways

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$4,300 to \$4,800

Thirty thatched bungalows on stilts over the water at Maroma Beach, each over 800 square feet. Glass floor panel in the room, your own infinity plunge pool on the deck, an indoor hot tub for two, an outdoor shower, and a ladder off your own deck straight down into the Caribbean. **These are the only true overwater bungalows in Mexico.** Leave Midway in the morning, be in the water by afternoon. **You asked about a massage: the All & More Inclusive rate already covers massages, facials and body scrubs,** and the round trip airport shuttle is included too.

Easiest trip

ARUBA

Aruba Ocean Villas

Savaneta · boutique, couples

Fly from O'Hare, nonstop

In the air about 5h

Airport to room 20 to 25 min drive

Door to door 7 to 8 hours

All inclusive No, meals extra

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$3,500 to \$4,200

Thatched villas over clear shallow water on the quiet south end, far from the high rise strip. Hardwood decks, ladders into the sea. **Aruba sits outside the hurricane belt,** so early October there is just a normal beach week instead of a gamble. Cheapest of the good ones.

Best weather odds

Lowest price

O'Hare only

THINGS TO DO

Private overwater dining cabana at The Old Man and The Sea **\$180 to \$300**

Morning sail and snorkel over the Antilla shipwreck **\$196**

Adults only

Seaweed possible

Sunset catamaran

\$118

BELIZE

Thatch Caye

a Muy'Ono Resort · private island

Fly from O'Hare, likely 1 stop

Then Puddle jumper + speedboat

Door to door about 12 hours

Usable time roughly 1.5 of 3 days

All inclusive Yes, transfers too

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$3,600 to \$6,200

Fifteen overwater bungalows on a private island inside the barrier reef. Genuinely beautiful, and the one we originally saw. **But October is Belize's wettest month, about ten inches of rain, at the peak of hurricane season,** and reef boat trips get cancelled. This is a February trip, not an October one.

Worst month

Two travel days

THINGS TO DO

Private candlelit dinner **in the package**
in the Honeymoon
Palapa, one table, over
the water

Oceanside couples **published rates**
massage at Serenity
Point or on your own
deck

BOCAS DEL TORO · PANAMA

Azul Paradise

overwater bungalows on the lagoon

Fly from O'Hare + 2nd flight

Then Boat to the island

Door to door about 14 hours

Usable time roughly 1.5 of 3 days

All inclusive Yes, on the package

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$2,750 to \$3,200

Ten bungalows on stilts over a turquoise lagoon, glass floor panel, private sundeck, hammock hanging over the water. **By far the cheapest real overwater bungalow on this list.** The catch is two of our three days go to airports, and the vibe is rustic barefoot rather than luxury.

Cheapest overall

Rustic

Two travel days

THINGS TO DO

Full day boat trip to **\$80 to \$140 shared**
Cayos Zapatillas

Dive or snorkel Tiger Rock **\$160 to \$220**

Guided barrier reef
snorkel, two drops

\$160 to \$250

BELIZE · PREMIUM

Cayo Espanto

Casa Ventanas · private island, 7 villas

Door to door about 12 hours

All inclusive Yes, private butler

Included 3 meals, drinks, sailboat

Extra charges 9% tax + 15% island fee

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$11,500 to \$14,000

A bungalow floating at the end of a 150 foot dock with its own butler and sailboat. Honestly **the best property on this entire page**. It is also the worst possible month to go, so my advice is to keep this one in our back pocket for February or March and give it five or six nights instead of three.

Most special

Wrong month

THINGS TO DO

Private snorkel charter to about **\$478**

Hol Chan and Shark Ray Alley, just the two of you

The Couples Escape spa package, delivered to your villa about **\$698**

ST. LUCIA

Sandals Grande St. Lucian

over the water butler bungalows

Fly from No October nonstop

Door to door 9 to 10 hours

All inclusive Yes, plus 3 resorts

Adults only Yes

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$7,100 to \$7,900

Beautiful bungalows and you get run of three Sandals resorts on the island. **The problem is purely arithmetic:** with a connection each way, two of our three days become travel days. Worth it for a week. Not worth it for three nights.

Full butler

Bad flight math

THINGS TO DO

Catamaran day sail down the coast to the Pitons **\$290**

Private candlelit dinner on the beach at the resort **\$199**

Sunset sail from Rodney Bay Marina **\$150**

ST. VINCENT

Sandals Saint Vincent

two story overwater villas

Fly from No nonstop, usually 2 stops

Door to door 12 to 14 hours

All inclusive Yes

Adults only Yes

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$11,500 to \$13,500

The newest and arguably the nicest overwater villas Sandals has built, two full stories out over the water. **Also the hardest to get to on the whole list.** Two connections each way means we would spend more time in airports than in the villa.

Newest villas

Two full travel days

THINGS TO DO

Private candlelight dinner for two on the sand **\$199**

Lover's Rock sunset catamaran up the leeward coast **\$213**

Mustique and Bequia island hopping **\$766**

JAMAICA

Sandals Jamaica

Royal Caribbean & South Coast

Fly from Midway route is Nov to Apr

Status Closed / renovating

Reopens December 18, 2026

AVAILABILITY

Not an option

Including it so you know I checked. **Royal Caribbean is closed until December 18, 2026** and reopening under a new name, South Coast is mid way through a \$200M rebuild after Hurricane Melissa, and the Midway to Montego Bay flight is a winter only route that does not run in October. Three strikes.

Unavailable

SIDE BY SIDE

The numbers, if you want them

Swipe sideways on your phone. Gold column is my pick.

	RIVIERA MAYA	ARUBA	BELIZE	PANAMA	ST. LUCIA
Property	Palafitos	Aruba Ocean Villas	Thatch Caye	Azul Paradise	Sandals Grande
Fly out of	Midway, nonstop	O'Hare, nonstop	O'Hare, 1 stop	O'Hare, 2 flights	O'Hare, 2 flights
Time in the air	3h 40m	about 5h	4h 22m to 7h	6h 30m plus boat	7h plus connect
Door to door	about 7 hours	7 to 8 hours	about 12 hours	about 14 hours	9 to 10 hours
Usable time	nearly all 3 days	nearly all 3 days	about 1.5 days	about 1.5 days	about 1.5 days
Per night	\$1,100 to \$1,250	\$549 to \$1,579	\$600 to \$1,200	\$375 to \$450	\$1,900 to \$2,022
All inclusive	Yes, plus butler	No	Yes	Yes, on package	Yes, plus butler
Flights for two	about \$800	\$1,000 to \$1,400	\$1,200 to \$1,600	\$1,400 to \$1,800	\$1,400 to \$1,800
Total, 3 nights	\$4,300 to \$4,800	\$3,500 to \$4,200	\$3,600 to \$6,200	\$2,750 to \$3,200	\$7,100 to \$7,900
Early Oct weather	Rain fading	Dry, 82 to 88°F	Wettest month	Wet season	Rainy season
Hurricane risk	Moderate, falling	Essentially none	Peak	Outside the belt	Moderate
Adults only	Yes	Couples focused	No	No	Yes
The catch	Seaweed is possible	Meals not included	Wrong month entirely	Two travel days	Two travel days

We cruise

Cheaper than every land option, but read the date note first.

Read this before you look at the cruises

Two hard facts the research turned up. **First**, almost every 3 night cruise sails Friday to Monday, and October 1 is a Thursday. Exactly one 3 night cruise sails our dates, and it is the one with no overwater anything. **Second**, and this is the important one: **no cruise line on earth sells an overnight overwater room**. You sleep on the ship. The closest thing that exists is a cabana you rent for the day. So there is no cruise that is our exact dates, three nights, and overwater all at once. The calendar forces a trade.

FORT LAUDERDALE · 3 NIGHTS

BEST CRUISE ON THE BOARD

Jewel of the Seas

Royal Caribbean · Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5

Nassau Sat Oct 3

CocoCay Sun Oct 4, our date

Ship size 2,100 guests

Airport to pier 4 miles, 10 minutes

Balcony for two about \$1,450 with taxes

EVERYTHING IN, FLIGHTS AND HOTEL INCLUDED

\$2,520 to \$3,000

It puts us on Perfect Day at CocoCay on **Sunday October 4, the actual anniversary date**, and a balcony here costs less than an interior cabin on the big flashy ship doing the identical island on the identical day. 2,100 guests instead of 5,668, so it is the calmest ship in the group. Fort Lauderdale has the shortest airport to pier hop in North America. We fly down Thursday the 1st, have our anniversary dinner in Fort Lauderdale that night, and sail Friday.

CocoCay on Oct 4

Quiet ship

Best value

Costs one Monday

PORT CANAVERAL · 3 NIGHTS

OUR EXACT DATES

MSC Seashore

Thu Oct 1 → Sun Oct 4 · Nassau + Ocean Cay

Leaves Thu Oct 1, 5:00 PM

Back Sun Oct 4, 7:00 AM

Work days burned Zero

Balcony for two about \$740 with taxes

Overwater None at all

EVERYTHING IN, FLIGHTS AND HOTEL INCLUDED

\$1,790 to \$2,350

The only cruise on earth that sails our exact anniversary dates. Confirmed three separate ways including Port Canaveral's own master ship schedule. No day off work, no shifting anything, and it is the cheapest thing on this entire page. The honest catch: Ocean Cay has zero overwater structures, and the ship leaves at 6:00 PM so we would miss the lighthouse light show and Junkanoo parade, which is the island's one romantic set piece.

No date change

Cheapest

No overwater

PORT CANAVERAL · 2 NIGHTS

THE SNEAKY GOOD ONE

Harmony of the Seas

Thu Oct 1 → Sat Oct 3 · CocoCay

Leaves Thu Oct 1, 4:00 PM

CocoCay Fri Oct 2, all day

Home Sat Oct 3, 6:00 AM

Work days burned Zero

Balcony for two about \$890 with taxes

EVERYTHING IN, FLIGHTS AND HOTEL INCLUDED

\$1,900 to \$2,200

This is the only ship in the entire fleet that leaves on October 1 and still reaches Perfect Day at CocoCay. It starts on our actual anniversary, gets us the island, and has us home Saturday morning with the whole rest of the weekend still ahead and not a single day off work. The tradeoff is that it is two nights instead of three, one port instead of two, and it is a big 5,479 guest ship on a weekend run.

Leaves Oct 1

Gets us CocoCay

No work missed

Only 2 nights

PORT CANAVERAL · 3 NIGHTS

Carnival Glory

Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5 · Celebration Key

Island day Saturday Oct 3

Fly from Midway to Orlando

Adults only spot Pearl Cove, 18+

Overwater Over a lagoon, day use

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$850 to \$1,450

Carnival's brand new Celebration Key has **Over-the-Lagoon Cabanas**, about \$518 for six hours, plus Pearl Cove Beach Club which is adults only with a heated infinity pool. It is a freshwater lagoon rather than the ocean, so it looks the part but it is not the same as CocoCay.

Adults only beach club

Lagoon, not ocean

MIAMI · 3 NIGHTS

Norwegian Getaway

Fri Oct 2 → Mon Oct 5 · Great Stirrup Cay

Island day Sunday Oct 4

Fly from Midway to Miami

Nonstops a day Exactly 1

Overwater Swings, not a cabana

CRUISE FARE FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$518 to \$758

The most adults-only feeling ship here. Vibe Beach Club onboard is 18 and over with its own bar and hot tubs. Two real problems though. Midway to Miami is one nonstop a day, so if it cancels the ship leaves without us. And the pier at Great Stirrup Cay closed for construction in April, so the island day may mean tender boats and queues instead of walking off.

Best adults only

One flight a day

Pier under construction

FORT LAUDERDALE · 4 NIGHTS

Disney Destiny

Thu Oct 1 → Mon Oct 5 · Castaway Cay

Leaves Thu Oct 1, 3:00 PM

Theme Halloween on the High Seas

Adults only Zones only

Overwater None anywhere in the fleet

CABIN FOR TWO, TAXES IN

\$2,242 to \$3,282

Newest Disney ship and it leaves on our actual anniversary. Nassau, then Castaway Cay with Serenity Bay, the adults only beach. Decorated for Halloween the whole way. Two honest problems: no overwater anything, and it is a family line, so a lot of kids.

Leaves Oct 1

4 nights

No overwater

The overwater cabana, honestly

Everybody sells this as the cruise version of an overwater bungalow. Here is the truth. **There are exactly twenty of them in the entire Royal Caribbean fleet.** On Sunday October 4 there will be about 7,768 people on that island from two ships, all of whom could want one, and they went on sale roughly a year ago. It is the one thing on the island that almost never

gets discounted, because it always sells out. At three and a half weeks out, **assume they are gone.**

Also worth knowing: it is a **day rental, roughly 7 in the morning to 5 in the evening**, and the going rate is around \$2,100. We would still sleep in a cabin. That is about \$265 an hour to stand over water.

The smarter play. A Coco Beach Club day pass is about \$284 for the two of us. Private beach, an infinity pool that hangs over the ocean, premium loungers, and a sit down lobster lunch. That is roughly ninety percent of the experience for about thirteen percent of the price. And on the Nassau day we could add Royal Beach Club Paradise Island as a second beach day, which also hedges us if the weather ruins one of them.

The cruises side by side

Swipe sideways. Gold columns are the three worth real thought.

	JEWEL	MSC SEASHORE	HARMONY	CARNIVAL GLORY	NCL GETAWAY
Leaves from	Fort Lauderdale	Port Canaveral	Port Canaveral	Port Canaveral	Miami
Sails	Fri Oct 2	Thu Oct 1	Thu Oct 1	Fri Oct 2	Fri Oct 2
Home	Mon Oct 5	Sun Oct 4	Sat Oct 3	Mon Oct 5	Mon Oct 5
Nights	3	3	2	3	3
Work days missed	One Monday	None	None	One Monday	One Monday
Private island	CocoCay, Oct 4	Ocean Cay, Oct 3	CocoCay, Oct 2	Celebration Key	Great Stirrup Cay
Overwater cabana	Yes, if any left	None	Yes, if any left	Over a lagoon	Swim-up bar
Ship size	2,100	4,540	5,479	2,980	3,960
Fare for two	about \$1,450	about \$740	about \$890	\$850 to \$1,450	\$518 to \$758
All in, with flights	\$2,520 to \$3,000	\$1,790 to \$2,350	\$1,900 to \$2,200	\$2,200 to \$2,900	\$2,000 to \$2,600
Best thing	CocoCay on our date, calm ship	Exact dates, cheapest	Oct 1 start, home Saturday	Adults only beach club	Most ship

My blunt read on cruising

These are two different vacations, not two prices for the same one. If waking up over the water is the whole point, the resort wins and it is not close, and we should stretch it to four or five nights so the flight is worth taking. A three night trip from Chicago to an overwater resort is mostly airports.

If three great nights together is the point, the cruise wins comfortably. Jewel of the Seas, a balcony, two Coco Beach Club day passes, and we still come home with about \$1,800 we did not spend.

The one thing I do not want us to do is pay cruise prices, sleep in a cabin, and then spend \$2,100 on a six hour cabana. That is the worst of both worlds. It lands near \$4,800 and costs more than the resort while giving us less of the thing we actually wanted.

One place the cruise genuinely wins is weather. A resort sits still and takes whatever October sends. A ship just moves, so a storm means a swapped port instead of a ruined anniversary.

So, pick one

You do not have to weigh all of that. Here is the short version, in the order I would choose.

1. **Riviera Maya.** If the experience is the point. Only one where we leave Midway in the morning and are in the water that afternoon.
2. **Aruba.** If you want zero weather anxiety. Outside the hurricane belt, cheapest of the good ones, we just pay for our own dinners.
3. **Panama.** If price is the point and you do not mind roughing the travel.
4. **Cayo Espanto.** Not now. Let's save this one and do it right in February.

Say a name and I will book it.

YOUR TURN

Tell me what you think

Type wherever you want. It saves as you go, so you can close this and come back.

Which one are you drawn to?

☐ Palafitos, Riviera Maya

☐ Aruba Ocean Villas

☐ Thatch Caye, Belize

☐ Azul Paradise, Panama

☐ Cayo Espanto, Belize

☐ Sandals St. Lucian

☐ Sandals St. Vincent

☐ Cruise: MSC Seashore

☐ Cruise: Harmony of the Seas

☐ Cruise: Jewel of the Seas

☐ Cruise: Carnival Glory

☐ Cruise: Norwegian Getaway

☐ Cruise: Disney Destiny

☐ None of these

☐ Still deciding

What made you pick that one?

Or what is making it hard to pick.

What would make it perfect?

A dinner, a spa day, a room upgrade, a photographer, anything.

Is anything a dealbreaker?

Long flights, connections, rain risk, no seaweed, whatever it is. Say it now.

How do you feel about the money?

☐ Spend what it takes

☐ The range shown is fine

☐ Let us keep it tighter

☐ Want to talk about it

Are the dates right?

October 1 to 4. Could we leave a day earlier or come back a day later?

Anything else on your mind?

Nothing sends until you tap one of those. Your answers stay on your phone until then.

Prices are published ranges and October averages, not live quotes for our exact dates, so the final number will move a little. Both passports are current, so nothing is blocking us. Palafitos has only thirty bungalows and we are about three and a half weeks out, so whichever way you lean, sooner is better.

Put together September 6, 2026.